

Bheja Fry!

Cell phones cause cancer: urban myth or scientific truth? Sriram Sharma and Dipayan Choudhary speak with a radiologist and an industry representative about hazards that come with owning a cell phone

A paper published in the *Science Journal Differentiation* says that repeated exposure to mobile phone radiation leads to the continuous manufacture of heat shock proteins within cells. Heat shock proteins are always present in cells at a low level, but are

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radiation. A mobile phone in the US operates between 850 MHz to 1,900 MHz. At that range the radiation produced is in the form of radio frequencies, the same as in a microwave. Just as a microwave heats food by means of radiation, with repeated usage of a cell phone, your cells too get heated.

However, researchers in the US and the UK say there is no

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Scratchy reports and unconfirmed studies have led to a belief among consumers that radiation from mobile phones causes cancer. But scientists at the National Cancer Institute (NCI) have concluded after a study they conducted that people who use cell phones are not at any greater risk to cancer than non-cell phone users. This study was conducted

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by mobile phones have led to it being mandatory for all cell phone manufacturers to put radiation ratings on all mobile phones sold in the US. This has been prompted by strict requirements from the regulatory authorities and I think that it is only a matter of time that

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manufactured in larger numbers when the cells are under stress because of heat or other environmental factors. If produced too often or for too long, they are known to cause cancer. This paper is the only evidence that heat shock proteins are produced because of electromagnetic devices.

Although, the FDA in the US has not reported any definite link between cancer and cell phones, US laws govern that the amount of radio frequency signals emitted by cell phones be printed on all phone packages. All mobile phones emit electromagnetic

direct link. The average incidence of brain cancer is six among a hundred thousand people. Unless there is evidence that the incidence is higher than that, no link between cancer and cell phones can be drawn. With electromagnetic radiation present in the atmosphere and many genetic factors also being responsible for causing cancer, it is difficult to point out the culprit.

Technology should not cause paranoia, but it should not cause carelessness either. The risks involved are low as compared to the benefits of this device. ■

to find a link between cell phone usage and brain disease and involved having over 800 test subjects answering questions regarding their cell phone usage patterns. The questions included number of minutes used and the model of the phone they operated. The results found no correlation between increased chances of developing Glioma, the most common form of brain cancer found in adults, and the usage of a mobile phone. The study is due to be published in the *New England Journal of Medicine*.

The increasing concern about radiation being emitted

such requirements are put in place for the Indian market.

The question still remains “Is answering a call going to kill me?” I don’t see a clear answer to that coming up in the near future. Maybe, five years to 10 years down the line, we might see a report that undeniably establishes that mobile phones are safe or otherwise. Until then I would recommend that you use a ‘hands free kit’. All you need to do is use a cell phone equipped with nothing more sophisticated than an earpiece that will allow you to take calls without the antenna being positioned near your head. ■

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Rajiv Sethi October 18 at 4.p.m.

